

CRAFTS



BASKETMAKERS, WOODCARVERS, and stone masons are craftspeople; they handmake objects that are both useful and attractive. Unlike other art forms, crafts are concerned with function as well as beauty: they are made to be used. Before the Industrial Revolution, craftspeople made the furniture for the home and tools for the workplace. Today these items are mass-produced in factories, so hand-crafted objects are valued for their individuality, and because they often come from a tradition that is centuries old.

Early craftspeople

Medieval craftspeople made their living from being skilled in one particular craft, such as coopering (barrel making), dyeing cloth, leather work, or goldsmithing. Each craft had its own guild, which was an association of the workers.

The guilds fixed prices and standards of work, and supported members who fell on hard times.



Dyers

Apprentices

Boys aged between 10 and 15, who wanted to learn a trade, would pay to start work as an apprentice to a craftsman. They spent between four and seven years learning every aspect of their craft from a master.



Judging a masterpiece

Masterpieces

At the end of his term as apprentice, each boy was required to produce an object that showed he had learned his craft. It was called a masterpiece, because it was judged by a master craftsman.

Types of crafts

Almost any material can be used in craft, from wood, stone, and metal, to beads, reeds, and shells. A craftsperson may sell work to earn a living, but craft is also a popular leisure activity.

Basketwork

From prehistoric times, basketmakers worldwide have woven materials, such as leaves, twigs, grass, and bark, to make unbreakable containers, to build boats and houses, and to make shoes and hats. Machines cannot yet match the fine technique displayed in a hand-woven basket.



Basketmaker, Spain

Traditional weaving technique

Embroidery

Embroidery, where designs are stitched onto fabric, decorates everyday clothing and furnishings, as well as garments for festive occasions. The embroiderer either draws the design onto the fabric before stitching it into the cloth, or develops it while she or he is working on the embroidery.

Butterfly detail, embroidered sleeve, China



African beaded work

Beadwork

Beads, made from materials such as wood, bone, shell, seeds, plastic, and glass, have been used to decorate material for centuries. The geometrical designs of Native North American beadworkers feature on clothing, bags, and shoes. African beadwork decorates vessels, festive garments, and jewellery.



Papier-mâché items, such as this bowl, can be simple to make.

Papier-mâché

Some people take up a craft as a hobby. One popular example is papier-mâché. Named after the French word meaning "chewed paper", it involves building up layers of paper and paste over a mould. When the paste dries, the paper is firm and can be painted and varnished.

Goggles for protection

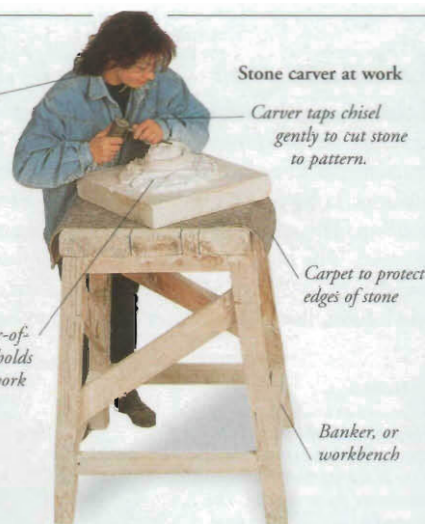
Stone carver at work

Carver taps chisel gently to cut stone to pattern.

Carpet to protect edges of stone

Plaster-of-Paris holds stonework steady

Banker, or workbench



Craft workshop

Many craftspeople have a workshop where they keep tools and materials. People who produce crafts objects for a living often sell goods from their workshop, so they can work when they are not helping customers.

Stonework

The craft of cutting and shaping stone for building is centuries old. Medieval masons prepared the stone to build churches, dams, and bridges; stone carvers, also known as banker masons, prepared ornamental finishes.



Mallet

Hammer-head chisel

Mallet-head chisels



Stone, trimmed (cut) into a small block

Marked out design



Shaping the stone

The carver begins by drawing a design onto a piece of acetate. This is then transferred to a block of stone as a guideline for cutting or carving. The stone carver then uses a toothed tool (a claw) to gouge out the basic design.

Finished article

A variety of chisels and carving gouges further define the shape of the carving, removing the worst of the marks left by the claw in the process. Finally, a double-ended file, called a riffler, is used to smooth out the marks left by the chisels. It takes years to master ornamental carving.



Finished baskets

This piece links the ribs that support stained glass in a cathedral window.

Cusp (from the Latin cuspis, or "spear head")

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